1. 玛纳斯

Suyundouke年长传承人1：**A Childhood Built Around Manas**

视频：**https://youtu.be/Oi6RjddkQlI**

Summary:
Suyundouke began learning *Manas* when he was about ten years old. As a child, he was so interested in the epic that he would secretly read it during class, even when his teacher tried to stop him. During school breaks, he performed parts of *Manas* for his classmates. After listening, his classmates would give him blank sheets of paper, and his mother would sew them together into a handmade notebook. Support from his mother, classmates, and teachers made *Manas* a strong part of his childhood and encouraged him to keep learning and performing it.

Comment:
I used to imagine cultural transmission as something formal, with an older expert teaching a younger student. Suyundouke's story made me see it differently. It showed me that transmission can begin in a very small community. A family, a group of classmates, and one child who wants to keep telling the story can already form a small network that helps a tradition continue.

Suyundouke年长传承人2：**A Book Can Preserve Manas. A Performer Makes It Alive.**

视频：**https://youtu.be/757WEDrOYJg**

Summary:
Suyundouke explains that written texts have helped preserve *Manas* more completely, especially parts that might otherwise be lost through oral transmission. But for many Manaschis, the version recorded in a book is still a "static" *Manas*. The epic becomes "living" through performance, when a Manaschi uses voice, rhythm, facial expressions, eye contact, and movement to bring emotion into the story and connect with the audience.

Comment:

I used to think that writing down an oral epic was one of the clearest ways to preserve it. Suyundouke made that idea more complicated for me. A written text can preserve the words, but it cannot fully preserve the experience of hearing them performed. Voice, emotion, rhythm, and movement are not simply additions to the story. They are part of what makes the tradition alive.

Tokom年轻传承人1：**Bringing Manas Into the Digital Age**

视频：**https://youtu.be/2JXF34YMSZk**

Summary:

Tokom describes how his relationship with *Manas* developed from memorization in childhood to deeper study, writing, and eventually digital media. Since 2022, he has used platforms such as Douyin, WeChat Channels, and Kuaishou to share performances, stories, and explanations of the epic. Because *Manas* is often too long for short-form platforms, he divides longer performances into smaller sections. For him, digital transmission means adjusting the form of the tradition so that it can fit the habits and attention of today's audiences.

Comment:
I used to think that bringing a tradition online simply meant giving more people access to it. Tokom made me notice that the platform itself can also change how a tradition is presented. A story that once unfolded through a long live performance may now be divided into several short videos. The content can remain connected to the same tradition, while the form changes for a different audience. It made me think about adaptation not only as a way to reach more people, but as part of how a tradition continues in a new media environment.

Tokom年轻传承人2：Memorizing Is Not the Same as Understanding

视频：https://youtu.be/5nd8TdwH0Fk

Summary:
Tokom explains that passing on *Manas* requires much more than memorization. After learning the text, he believes a Manaschi must understand it, study it, and reorganize it before sharing it with others. He has read *Manas* six or seven times since childhood and still feels there are parts he does not fully understand. For him, the epic is almost like an entire field of study, containing history, customs, culture, and knowledge from different communities.

Comment:
I often thought of memorization as one of the main signs that someone had truly learned a tradition. Tokom made me see that memory is only the beginning. Understanding, research, and interpretation are also part of transmission. What interested me most is that passing something on does not mean repeating it exactly. It means doing enough work with the material that you can make sense of it and help someone else understand it too.

Tokom年轻传承人3：The Same Story Is Never Told Exactly the Same Way

视频：https://youtu.be/5Xsm-ms13aU

Summary:
Tokom describes *Manas* as a "living epic" because the same story is never performed in exactly the same way. A Manaschi may change the tone, rhythm, gestures, wording, or level of detail depending on the setting, the audience, and the performer's own state. Even so, the main structure and storyline remain consistent. This balance between continuity and improvisation is part of what allows *Manas* to stay alive as an oral tradition.

Comment:
I often thought of preservation as keeping something unchanged, but Tokom's explanation suggests a different idea. *Manas* stays recognizable because its core story remains, even while each performance can change. That made me think more carefully about the line between retelling and changing a tradition. Maybe the question is not whether change happens, but which parts can change without losing what makes the tradition itself.

2. 木卡姆

Turghun-**How Do You Preserve a Tradition Without Freezing It?**

https://youtu.be/YIqtAFit-B8

Summary：
Professor Turghun describes preservation and development as a balance rather than a choice between two extremes. He believes important parts of a tradition should be protected, but the ways it is presented may need to change as younger audiences and media habits change. Using Xinjiang folk music as an example, he explains how new arrangements, new languages, and online platforms can help unfamiliar audiences enter a tradition. For him, the goal is not simply to tell young people that a tradition is valuable, but to help them understand why it matters.

Comment：
I often think the hardest question is not whether a tradition should change, but how far that change can go. Professor Turghun's answer made me think about adaptation as a question of access and boundaries at the same time. A new format can help more people enter a tradition, but it should not erase the features that make the tradition distinct. That balance seems to be one of the central challenges of keeping cultural traditions meaningful today.

Madina-**How Do You Make a Tradition Meaningful to a Child?**

https://youtu.be/U34Z5pbqD04

Summary：

Madina explains that young children do not need to begin by memorizing names, history, or musical terms. She suggests letting them watch and listen first, then asking what they noticed. Their own observations can become the starting point for learning about the performers, instruments, stories, and history behind the Twelve Muqam. For her, curiosity should come before explanation, so that children first connect with the experience and then gradually understand what they saw.

Comment:

I often assumed that understanding had to come before interest. Madina's approach made me think about the order differently. Someone new to a tradition may first need a detail that catches their attention, such as a sound, an instrument, a person, or a story. That small moment of curiosity can become the beginning of deeper learning. It made me realize that making a tradition accessible does not always mean simplifying it. Sometimes it means giving people the right place to enter.

3. 江格尔

Nima-**Tradition Has to Change to Stay Alive**

https://youtu.be/uB5oyJSCh4I

Summary：
Nima explains that *Jangar* has never remained completely unchanged because it has been passed down orally for generations. While details may shift, the main story and core ideas remain. Since around 2012, he and other performers have experimented with new ways of presenting the epic by shortening long sections, rearranging the music, adding instruments, and using throat singing. For Nima, these changes do not replace the original story. They help the tradition reach contemporary audiences while keeping its core recognizable.

Comment：
I often thought of innovation and preservation as two opposite directions. Nima's approach made that distinction feel less simple. The real challenge seems to be deciding what must remain recognizable and what can change with the audience and the time. A tradition does not have to stay in exactly the same form to remain itself. In some cases, changing the way it is presented may be what allows its core story to keep being heard.

分别展示传统版江格尔和改编版江格尔演奏视频（暂定），
标题：**Traditional vs Adapted Performance**

传统：https://youtu.be/HzAUJqb24Gg
改编：https://youtu.be/1UrW_ywKitI

4. 蒙古族长调

Wutunasheng-**Teaching One Line at a Time**

https://youtu.be/nNJUa9bjLqw

Summary：
Wutunasheng explains that Mongolian Long Song can still be taught without formal music theory or written notation. He learned the tradition orally and now teaches his students in much the same way, guiding them through the melody and lyrics one line at a time. Students who read staff or numbered notation can use it as an additional tool, while others continue to learn by listening and repeating. Students who learn quickly may also help teach their classmates, creating another layer of transmission within the group.

Comment：
I often assumed that writing music down would naturally make it easier to teach. What I saw here was more flexible. Notation can help, but the tradition does not depend on it. Listening, repetition, and learning directly from another person still remain at the center of the process. I was especially interested in how students can become teachers themselves, so transmission does not move in only one direction.

Wutunasheng-**A Performance Is More Than Singing the Right Notes**

https://youtu.be/MdwHZsXvFEQ

Summary：
Wutunasheng explains that a strong Long Song performance is judged by more than vocal technique. Posture, stage presence, traditional clothing, confidence, and emotional expression all contribute to the performance as a whole. He believes a song should feel connected from beginning to end and should be sung sincerely enough to move the audience. That confidence on stage, he adds, comes from regular practice and long-term preparation.

Comment：
I was used to thinking about musical performance mainly in terms of how accurately someone played or sang. Wutunasheng described something much broader. Voice, body, clothing, confidence, and emotion all belong to the performance together. It made me realize that what is being passed on is not simply a set of correct notes, but an entire way of performing and communicating with an audience.

5. 阿肯阿依特斯

Aqyn Aitys: **Listen, Think, Answer — All in Real Time**

https://youtu.be/jByd0tUbYGQ

Summary：
Aqyn Aitys is a form of live poetic exchange rather than a rehearsed song. Two performers listen to each other, think quickly, and respond immediately through improvised lyrics, melody, and dombra playing. Each Aqyn develops a personal vocal style and chooses melodic patterns

that fit their own voice. The exchange can be competitive, humorous, or playful, but it always depends on the ability to turn thought into poetry and music in real time.

Comment:
What interested me most was how many things have to happen at the same time. An Aqyn has to listen carefully, understand the other person, think of a response, shape it into poetry, and sing it with music almost immediately. It made me see improvisation as much more than spontaneity. It depends on language, memory, musical skill, and a large amount of knowledge already built up before the performance begins.

Aqyn Aitys: **The Art of the Comeback**

https://youtu.be/Xim-shfhH6E

Summary:
Humor is an important part of Aqyn Aitys. Performers do not simply take turns singing. They tease, joke, challenge each other, and react to what is happening in the moment. In male-female duets, this can become especially playful, with compliments, witty replies, and verbal sparring built into the exchange. Audience reaction also matters. Laughter and attention become part of the performance and help shape its rhythm and energy.

Comment:
I used to think of improvisation mainly as the ability to create something quickly. Aitys showed me that timing and audience response matter just as much. A good comeback has to be clever, musical, and immediate, but it also has to land with the people listening. That made me realize that this tradition is not only a conversation between two performers. It is also a conversation with the audience.

Closing Interview -插入音频

标题：Keeping Oral Traditions Alive: Language, Change, and the Future of Cultural Transmission

采访者：Dan Wang is a professor at Xinjiang Arts University whose research focuses on Kazakh traditional music, oral performance, and related cultural traditions in Xinjiang. Her work includes areas such as Aqyn Aitys and other forms of Kazakh musical and oral culture. In this interview, she discusses the preservation of oral traditions, language and translation, digital media, and the challenges of cultural transmission today.

（标题和采访者介绍可以放在listen那个主页，点击下拉加载后放正文和采访音频）

正文：

Keeping an Oral Tradition Does Not Mean Turning It Into a Fixed Object

When we talk about preserving oral cultural heritage, one of the first questions is often how to keep it from disappearing. Professor Wang describes two processes that are happening at the same time.

The first is documentation. Oral music and literature can now be recorded through audio, video, written text, and musical notation. These records create an archive and reduce the risk that important material will simply disappear when an older performer is no longer able to pass it on.

But documentation alone is not the same as transmission.

Professor Wang emphasizes that oral traditions also need to continue through people. A song that was traditionally learned by listening should not automatically become something that exists only on a written score. Protecting inheritors and allowing knowledge to continue from one person to another helps preserve the original way in which the tradition functions.

This creates an important tension. A tradition needs to be recorded so that it is not lost, but it also needs to remain something that people continue to practice.

Language Is More Than a Tool for Communication

One of the strongest themes in the interview is language.

Many younger members of minority communities now grow up using Mandarin more often in school and daily life. Professor Wang sees this as a real challenge for oral traditions, because

language is not simply the container for a story or a song. It carries ways of thinking, expression, rhythm, and cultural experience.

At the same time, she does not reject bilingual performance. Some performers now sing Aitys, Manas, or other traditional material in Mandarin so that more people can understand it. In some cases, this is not something imposed from outside. It is a choice made by the performers themselves because they want to reach a wider audience.

The difficulty begins with translation.

Words can often be translated, but the deeper cultural logic behind them may be much harder to reproduce. Different languages organize emotion, metaphor, rhythm, and meaning in different ways. As Professor Wang puts it, learning another language can mean entering another way of life.

A strong translation therefore requires more than replacing one word with another. It may need to consider the original expression, the rhythm of the music, the habits of the language, and the cultural meaning behind the words.

Why Video Can Preserve Something a Score Cannot

The conversation then turns to documentation itself.

Professor Wang explains why newer approaches such as audiovisual ethnography have become important in music research. No system of musical notation can capture everything that happens in a live performance. A score may record pitch or rhythm, but it cannot fully preserve facial expressions, gestures, the reactions of the audience, or the atmosphere of a particular moment.

Video can hold more of that context.

This is especially important for traditions that contain improvisation. The exact words, gestures, or musical choices of one performance may never appear in exactly the same way again. Recording that moment makes it possible to preserve not only the work itself, but also the way people performed, responded, and interacted.

For Professor Wang, the strongest form of documentation is therefore multimodal. Written records, audio, video, and other forms of documentation can support one another rather than compete.

Digital Media Changes the Form, but Change Is Not Automatically Loss

Short video creates another problem.

Many oral traditions can last for hours. Muqam, Manas, and other forms do not naturally fit into a thirty-second or five-minute video. When they enter platforms built around short attention spans, they inevitably change.

Professor Wang does not see all change as a threat.

Her view is that traditional culture has always changed because the people who carry it are also living in changing societies. When performers choose new platforms or new ways of presenting their culture, this can be understood as their own response to contemporary life.

She makes an important distinction, however. Accepting change does not mean that every change is equally valuable.

Digital media can introduce a tradition to people who might never otherwise encounter it. At the same time, fragmented or poorly informed adaptations can weaken or distort its cultural meaning. The task is therefore not simply to stop change, but to think carefully about what is changing and what remains.

What Can Change, and What Must Remain?

This leads to one of the most difficult questions in the interview: how do we know when a tradition has changed too much?

Professor Wang does not offer a simple rule. Instead, she points to several things that can help us judge.

A tradition normally has a history of transmission across generations. It also has certain core features that allow the community itself to continue recognizing it as that tradition. Performance settings may change. A practice that once belonged to work, ritual, or everyday life may later move onto a stage. New media and new forms of presentation may appear.

But if the people who carry the tradition still recognize its core, and if a meaningful chain of transmission remains, change does not necessarily mean that the tradition has disappeared.

Time also matters. Some changes may only be understood clearly after a community has lived with them for a longer period.

This shifts the question from “Has the tradition changed?” to a more useful one: “What has changed, and what still makes this tradition recognizable to the people who carry it?”

Research Has to Go Back to Language and Fieldwork

Near the end of the conversation, Professor Wang turns from cultural transmission to academic research.

For anyone studying oral music or oral literature, she sees language as a basic requirement. A researcher who only reads translated texts may miss the relationship between music, words, and cultural meaning. This is especially difficult in Xinjiang, where researchers may be working across very different language families.

But learning vocabulary is not enough.

Researchers also need to understand the life behind the language. That requires spending time in the communities where the tradition exists, listening to how people use the language, and understanding the social and cultural environment in which music and oral literature are performed.

For Professor Wang, this is one of the central challenges of studying oral culture. Its meaning does not exist only in a text, a melody, or a recording. It exists in the relationship between all of them.

A Living Tradition Is Both Preserved and Changing

Across the interview, a larger idea gradually emerges.

Preservation is not the same as freezing a tradition in one historical form. Recording matters. Archives matter. Language matters. Inheritors matter. But so do new audiences, new technologies, and the choices made by the communities themselves.

A living tradition may need both continuity and change.

The challenge is not to choose one over the other. It is to preserve enough of the language, knowledge, performance practice, and cultural meaning that the tradition can still be recognized, while allowing the people who carry it to decide how it will continue in the world they live in now.